DBRAC Debrief
March 31, 2016

Approved May 19, 2016

Members Present: Tony Magliano, Sarah Lewins, Scott Bailey, Hector Roche, Pamela Kislak, Neisha Saxena, Mike Reunert, Joe Zehnder, Alice Perry, Jason Trombley (had to leave early)
Staff Present: Shawn Helm, Judy Brennan, Erin Barnett

What worked, what didn't:

- Ed Washington, Fair Housing Tour, really powerful. Do that for new members. I learned that the black community wanted to be a critical mass at a limited number of schools instead of being 7 percent of every school;.

- Loved the contracts with culturally specific partners. We were really culturally responsive; we hired organizers to help us reach communities we wouldn't have heard from.

- The partner meetings with table talk across schools and communities, where people had to talk across issues and needs; and also allowed for it to be accessible for not just people comfortable coming to meetings. Also made it like it wasn't run by PPS or DBRAC; it was more grassroots.

- The extra effort we made with PPS 2025 to get voices we were not hearing from.

- When we did small group work we made strides rather than moving it as a whole committee. Very effective in small groups.

- But needed more time for the report outs for the small groups because I wanted to better understand WHY a group made a certain call on something.

- Needing to have staff be clear up front that tonight we have to make a decision not that we are just going to do dialogue. We need to know what we have to do so we can help keep on track.

- APANO Youth listening session was really outstanding; helpful insightful comment.

- Some meetings, too much on the agenda including public comment. Need to hit fewer key agenda items when we need to have deep discussion. The extended work session was really effective at PSU. Maybe do fewer longer meetings.

- Also I needed time to absorb issues so that I could be ready with my A Game for a meeting. Needing to get info to committee members in time to absorb. I missed having Max Tuttle, student, at the table long term. SuperSAC kids were able to do a great job of sharing their views and wrestling with the issues and telling parents to go on one side of the room so students could use their voices. We need other ways to engage students.

- Really liked hearing from students. Liked the Harrison Park students who did a class assignment to write their views on the issues. Would like to get the data at the end of the meeting for the next meeting so that we can absorb it – at least the data that you already planned to roll out not stuff that you have to go create in response to what happened at that meeting.

- Public needed to understand that there would be iterations; that the engagement was to inform what we would do next and that the scenarios would change.

- Verbal comment and the emails – there were a lot of alternative proposals. Challenge of which ones to actually look into. We needed more of a filter for staff, more direction. We asked them to get a lot of data to be responsive but we needed a litmus test, a way to have criteria for which of these alternative plans/data requests we should pursue.

- We've had three school communities come to us and tell us that the people who said they represented our school did not represent our school and we need you to help us with some healing.

- What is within the purview of the community? I just don't know; to be honest there are communities out there in anticipation of our next round are forging alternative plans right now and that's good but I also know there is limited context. And they don't know what they control. They don't know what their choices are or how much leverage they actually can have. Everyone wants the world for their children. Need the parameters within which the community can operate.

- I feel like we were really responsive, to the point that communities thought we were switching things up on them when we were trying to be responsive.

- We need at least two student representatives. And embedding them at the table and letting them know how often we meet.

- What if we could give them credit for their participation? (Everyone agrees)

- We were missing someone who spoke about program and we ended up in a circular discussion. Need someone from the Office of Teaching & Learning.

- We needed to know what the program is and why.

- There was a lot of stuff we needed. The middle school program doesn't exist. We didn't have a clear study of the number of sections needed for the middle school program because we didn't have OTL. We had Sarah Singer and Shawn who made an educated guess and we had principals who had experience.

- Ass't Supt Chris Russo/OTL is on the implementation committee. Front and center on our implementation team right now is completing the MS program. It is high on our list of priorities to get it done. (Comment by Tony Magliano, who is on the MS implementation team)

- We needed a clearer understanding of the constraints; and we needed to give those to the community so that again they understood the parameters. And ask for ideas and be clear about challenges. Who hasn't been heard – getting the black experience in the beginning with the history, we also need the Hispanic perspective of history in Portland, like to hear from low-income white families. Need those voices heard.

- At Ainsworth I didn't hear from the parents I wanted to hear from; I heard from highly privileged. We did not hear from a lot of folks at the other end of the spectrum.

- And that affected the result.

- I was at that meeting (Spanish-Language meeting at Mittlman Community Center). People at the lower end of the income spectrum were there at the meeting and I don't know if they supported the views being expressed but they did say that they had not been engaged.

- We all needed a Chromebook to track all the data/documents; all that paper became unmanageable and hurt my heart. Need a better use of technology. Tracking the data and aligning it with various topics and meeting agendas. Three hole punch the paper at least so that you have a way to binder all of it.

- Trying to do tabulated reports that is all about one topic so that we can track.

- This was a very diligent group. It affects your ability to give input if you are counting on folks to be experts. I felt the tension that I was not going to become an expert in this; so you do a committee a disservice when you bury them in data/paper. Our group was very cognizant of that and interested in the data but it was hard to track where we were in a discussion at any given time, or the arc of the process. Needed to be able to see the arc better.

Writing the Values Framework took forever because I guess we were norming. Hard to know from one meeting to the next, what progress we made. Because we got behind and then we felt the timeline was unreasonable.

- We had all this flare up around it's unreasonable in the timing; People would have turned away from our process; it would not have been allowed. But we had to push hard to get through it/get it done. Need to consolidate what we did – so people can clearly follow the process and help keep on track. The KPIs were a great moment but at the end we all found the 4-5 things we were really tracking – could not do so many KPI-s. I'm in the middle of a process now where we are doing 3 hour meetings; I think the 3 hour meeting where lots on the agenda, prefer 3 hour where you have time to reflect and resolve. Sitting through group training where still trying to norm, getting to know each other, I never really understood all the dynamics at the table.

- All the storming and norming at the beginning was really hard and lengthy; then we went long at the end and we had to rush; didn't have time to hear each other's voices; it takes time to hear voices. We needed to move to small groups sooner.

- But caution that small groups can also favor some voices. So have to be careful.

- It felt more like report outs and NOT conversation. Agreement.

- I found the meeting process challenging. I think we were inundated by the data which is good and I know I asked for more too. I think the staff did a good job of helping us with that. Even so, it was still really hard. Wanted a way to see the through line. I liked the small group process better; we got to dive deeper. But it felt really rushed and hard and at the same time what do you do with a huge group of this size and you have deadlines.

- We had same with SACET. We spent 75% of our time storming and norming and then (Scott adds: then we came back from a break and just did it; it's a miracle).

- Trying to stay focused on the task at hand and then not being able to stay focused; having to balance community feedback. It felt so rushed. Trying to remember the feedback and the data and do a really good job and raise a family and have a job. Coming up with a product that met the needs of today and also worked into the future. It was a big job.

- (In response to staff question: What do you think about having Chromebooks where we have electronic folders where we store information.) What we

want is a database that is searchable so we can go by date or topic. So if you have Chromebook or your own device.

- Staff response: It would be easy to do a Google sheet, use URL's.

- The dot graph that showed the building capacity and that was a powerful visual.

- A handful of documents always came with me – the most updated map, the dot chart and the KPI's.

- I have in mind this Google map that you could go big or small and click on a school and the demographics would pop up.

- School size, capture rate, transfer, that concentric circles piece.

- If we could have made a KPI cheat sheet, that would have been great. I kept waiting for that. If I had known that it was going to roll up into these five numbers, it would have helped. So more about charting the process in a way that you see where you are going and can help get there.

- I wanted to see the KPI's against the dot chart; does this fit our values, or not. The matrix is really helpful.

- When people ask me what did you do on DBRAC, the thing I say is we made a decision to go away from K-8s to MS/K-5s. Observation is that for the first six months that was off the table and not part of our charter. Then we ended up going there. A helpful document was the spreadsheet of the list of classes offered at MS and then at K-8s and the huge disparity.

- It was that moment at PSU that we clicked.

- Yes we clicked into the idea that we needed to go from K-8s to K-5/MS.

- Our discussion and dialogue took us to what we needed to actually be doing. Not just boundaries, that buildings were not right-sized.

- What made me think about the 6-8 program was hearing from Scott parents about their complete lack of electives. We all came to the same conclusions but we did so differently.

- When it got dropped on us that three sections per grade was golden, where the hell did that come from? That was a breakthrough moment. That helped me see what we were shooting for.

- Sarah Lewins helped describe it; Sarah Singer also helped describe it too.

- That was a big moment that gave me what I needed to understand it. I could not figure out why we did not have that sooner….

- Staff response: It wasn't analysis that we had when we started. We were developing it in real time.

- If we had been clear that configuration was what we were going to do then we would not have been the group to do that.

- I remember asking the question of Carole, who will make the decision on K8 vs. K5/MS and Carole asked if we would give it a shot and we ended up deciding we would.

- I remember the vote.

- We were on the fence but then we were concerned about transparency and we had to do this work.

- But we couldn't redraw boundaries without addressing the configuration piece once we knew about it.

- Parts that were challenging to integrate – community and racial history; the individual school program history tied to that but not always. Tied to that was also about community resiliency; our communities were resilient; they made the most of bad situations in our schools and had pride and ownership in that. The community engagement and translation/interpretation has to be built in. In the end it hurt us and hurt PPS because families didn't feel engaged. White lower class families didn't feel engaged either. Part of that is not the result of our process but human nature; people lead their lives and then they become engaged when it's real for them. The absenteeism on the committee; I hoped we would reach out to the people who were more absent to find out why. We may not be able to fix that but we should ask the question.

- I think Jason made attempts to identify that but it's an ongoing concern for me. We lost members of communities of color in that process too. When we translated from Spanish to English I realized how much people are excluded from the process. Getting translation/interpretation right is huge.

Next Steps
Presentation by Judy:

We now have a plan for program and enrollment/boundary and why. This is the first time since I've been at PPS.

Work to do: (See PPT)
- boundaries for Ockley Green/feeder schools
- two new middle schools that will be in August 2017
- bring on Rose City Park and assign boundaries
- we are starting from building blocks, not from scratch

Planning the next process for Spring:
- Here are the meeting dates
- Here are the basic agendas with the key pieces we need to hit.
- Here are the constraints and what is realistic.
- Highlight the decision points.
- Program decisions like DLI programs, what to do with them

We want to start from the work that is already done and make use of the feedback; an advanced starting point. Then we need to be targeted about the feedback we are asking for and what we can use.

Committee feedback:
It (community input) can't be wide open; we need to say what we need and not what we don't need, such as opening a new school.

By doing it piecemeal we can run into problems such as running up against the SE border. If the Focus Option committee comes in the summer and says move SE Focus Options that will impact what we've done.

We are not trying to create chaos for your children—but we are; it is no longer a city where you move into a city and you expect to go to one particular school. We have to seed the idea that we have to be more flexible. Things are going to change.

(Staff response) There are risks in localizing and globalizing; this is more piecemeal and also is about people's ability to process and manage change.

I don't think it's fair to say that we aren't thinking of the impact at Laurelhurst or Vestal; staff is thinking about what options do we have a Laurelhurst. It isn't total isolation in which we will make these decisions.

My ideal is we do it all at once. Otherwise it can come back around.

The pieces we have to move are big but not vast. Need to break it down for us. Define the range of views.